# The AI Feature Readiness Check

Nine questions to ask from the product chair, not the machine learning chair, before an AI feature ships. I have led ML and algorithm-centric products since 2017, and every expensive failure I have watched would have been caught by one of these. Write real answers, not reassurances.

### 1. THE OUTCOME, TECHNOLOGY-FREE

Describe what the customer gets without using the words AI, model or agent.

If it cannot be described, it is a demo, not a product.

### 2. THE COST OF A WRONG ANSWER

What happens, specifically, when the feature gets it wrong? Who pays, and what do they lose?

Charming once, fatal twice. Trust is a metric you design, not one you hope to see.

### 3. THE MOMENT AFTER

What does the user see and do immediately after a wrong or low-confidence answer?

The failure state is the product. If it is unspecified, the feature is unfinished.

### 4. CONFIDENCE THRESHOLDS

At what confidence do we show, hedge or stay silent? Who chose those numbers, and on what evidence?

### 5. THE EVAL AS A PRODUCT ARTEFACT

What does the evaluation set contain, who weighted it by customer impact, and when was it last refreshed?

Accuracy on the eval is not accuracy as experienced. The product chair co-owns the eval or the eval measures the wrong thing.

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### 6. UNIT ECONOMICS

What does one interaction cost today, and what does the curve look like at ten times the volume?

### 7. THE BORING TEST

Would this initiative still make sense if the technology were boring? What is the hypothesis, and what evidence would kill it?

### 8. DATA HONESTY

Where does the training and grounding data come from, what is it missing, and who does that gap disadvantage?

### 9. THE KILL CRITERIA

What measured result, by what date, would retire this feature? Who has the authority to pull it?

Features without kill criteria do not get killed; they get quietly ignored while costing money.

> **How I use this:** at the go/no-go, out loud, with engineering and the data science lead in the room. Questions 2, 3 and 9 cause the arguments, which is exactly their purpose. A team that answers all nine crisply is ready. A team that answers eight is nearly ready. A team that bristles is telling you something.

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